Use case: handing live credentials to an external team, for $0.10

Two agents, same tool, four days after launch. One path was a one-shot; the other took 45 minutes and three humans. Both are honest, and the difference is the whole lesson.

The one-shot: Agent Kepler sends Twilio credentials

An external dev team building on AWS needed live Twilio API credentials to wire a WhatsApp sandbox webhook. Agent Kepler (Hermes runtime):

1. Reconnected to Qatom on its own (OAuth, no human step).
2. Found "Secure Secrets Exchange: create one-time secret link" (item 199) in the catalog and read the public llms.txt.
3. Logged into the Twilio console and minted a secondary, revocable auth token instead of exposing the primary.
4. Encrypted the bundle itself (AES-256-GCM, `sse-e2e-v1`), then bought the link: 0.10 USD-TDN from its own agent wallet, inside a human-set auto-approve limit.
5. Sent the link to the team's lead via Hassan. The recipient needs only a browser — no account, no wallet.

The one human step: a Twilio SMS login code, typed into a secure prompt so it never entered the chat. Total cost: $0.10. No server, payment rail, or log ever saw the secret — the key travels only in the link's `#` fragment, which browsers never send.

The hard path: Torque receives a webhook the human way

Torque (Muse agent) needed the AquaSentinel webhook address, sent as a one-time Secure Secrets Exchange link by email:

1. The agent's email connector redacted the link — the URL arrived as a credential reference, not clickable. Dead on arrival.
2. Opening the real email in a browser needed a separate Gmail sign-in, which stalled.
3. A human pasted the link into chat — twice missing the `#key` fragment (display text copied instead of the link address). The viewer page correctly reported "missing key" and did *not* burn the one-time view.
4. A fresh link was issued; opened once, revealed once, server copy deleted.

Total: ~45 minutes and three human-in-the-loop steps. The product worked exactly as documented at every step — the friction was entirely in the delivery path (redaction → human

relay → copy error).

The win: the agent-native retrieve

The request/retrieve flow (items 198/197) skips the clickable link entirely. A Claude agent on the central side created the secret request with one catalog call (~$0.10), and Torque retrieved it with one `agent_checkout` on item 197 carrying the request handle: secret delivered in ~2 seconds, $0.00, deleted from the server after. No browser, no copying, no human in the loop.

Bonus: the agent-native path caught a real setup bug — the first request-item purchase was paid but not delivered (wrong token in the Qatom dashboard settings). It was fixed, the second purchase worked, and the failed purchases were refunded. The link route never touched that code path.

The takeaway for builders

If you're handing secrets to agents, don't send a clickable link — hand them a request handle. The link is the key: whoever opens it first gets the secret, and it has to survive email redaction, sign-ins, and copy-paste. The request flow is the agent-native one-shot, and it already exists.